Patios and flooring — slab base, floor finish, damp and drainage

What is the difference between a concrete floor base and a floor finish?

A **concrete floor base** is a base layer or supporting element on which flooring may be laid. A **floor finish** is the walkable floor finish, such as tiles or another suitable material. They are not synonyms; the construction system and intended use determine the appropriate build-up.

Can the floor finish be replaced without rebuilding the slab base?

Yes, if the substrate is stable, level, compatible and free from defects that could undermine the new finish. Cracks or dampness arising from the base should be assessed and repaired before covering it.

Why does a patio collect puddles after new tiles are laid?

Possible causes include inadequate gradients, blocked drains, junction details and changes in floor level. Check how water flows; waterproof tiles alone cannot compensate for inadequate drainage.

What should be checked before waterproofing a terrace?

Inspect the substrate, leaks, falls, drains, joints, thresholds and junctions. Choose a system compatible with exposure and use, and record watertightness tests where appropriate.

Can new patio tiles be laid over existing ones?

Only if the existing build-up is sound and compatible and the added height, door clearance, falls and drainage remain acceptable. Adding layers can conceal damp problems and raise the floor enough to obstruct a door.

How does a shrinkage crack differ from structural movement?

A single crack is insufficient to determine its cause. Record width, continuity, change over time and relationship to structural elements. Movement, stepped cracking or safety concerns require assessment by a competent specialist.

Why are movement joints important?

Temperature changes and substrate movement can transfer stress to the finish. System joints must be designed and respected; filling them with rigid mortar may encourage debonding.

Which flooring suits a wet outdoor area?

Consider slip resistance, local frost exposure, water absorption, maintenance and installation method. Verify applicable safety requirements and declared product performance.

What happens if the drain sits higher than the finished floor?

Water may remain trapped. Assess whether the build-up levels, falls, waterproofing and connection can be adapted. Grouting over puddling areas alone is not a solution.

When should the entire outdoor floor be rebuilt?

When combined defects in the substrate, waterproofing, falls or widespread debonding make durable localized repair unfeasible. The whole assembly requires assessment.

Case PA-11 — Patio with a low door threshold

Hypothetical evaluation case, not work performed or a service promised by Riansares 4R.

Situation: The owner proposes installing a new floor finish over the old one.

Checks: Measure threshold levels, drainage direction and existing gradient.

Possible scope: Over-tiling only where function and drainage are preserved.

Decision criterion: Do not accept a finished level that allows rainwater to enter.

Evidence to retain: Level drawings and photographs.

Case PA-12 — Hollow-sounding floor tiles

Hypothetical evaluation case, not work performed or a service promised by Riansares 4R.

Situation: Several tiles sound hollow and others are cracked.

Checks: Assess substrate condition, extent and moisture.

Possible scope: Local replacement or a wider intervention according to extent.

Decision criterion: Do not treat new adhesive as a substitute for diagnosis.

Evidence to retain: Damage map and photographs.

Industry references and scope

- CTE_HS.
- CTE_SUA.

These sources provide general context; they do not attest to work performed by Riansares 4R. Technical requirements must be checked for the intervention and applicable jurisdiction.